

WIN YOUR FIRST GOVERNMENT CONTRACT

The first-time bidder's field guide to registrations, certifications, finding the right solicitations, and writing proposals that score — updated for the 2026 FAR overhaul.

MILLENNIALS CREATIVES LLC

Woman-Owned · Minority-Owned · SAM Registered · CAGE 18ZQ0

Written by a certified small business that submits government bids every month.

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Before we start: what this guide is

This guide is written by Millennials Creatives LLC, a woman-owned, minority-owned small business registered in SAM.gov, based on our own experience registering, certifying, finding, and bidding on federal, state, local, and tribal opportunities. It is educational material, not legal, tax, or accounting advice. Procurement rules change — especially right now, in the middle of the largest rewrite of federal acquisition regulation in four decades — so always verify requirements against the current solicitation and official sources (SAM.gov, acquisition.gov, SBA.gov) before you act.

What makes this guide different: we are not consultants selling you a dream from the sidelines. We submit bids month in and month out through the same portals you'll use. Everything here is the playbook we run ourselves — including the mistakes that cost us time so they don't have to cost you any.

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Why Government Contracts — and Why You

The U.S. government is the largest buyer on Earth. Federal agencies alone award hundreds of billions of dollars in contracts every year, and tens of billions of that is set aside specifically for small businesses — with dedicated programs for woman-owned, minority-owned, veteran-owned, HUBZone, and 8(a) firms. Add state, county, city, school district, and tribal purchasing, and government is buying almost everything: cleaning, catering, trucking, software, training, consulting, signage, construction, healthcare services, and more.

Three truths first-timers don't hear often enough:

- **Government buyers need new vendors.** Agencies have small-business participation goals, and contracting officers routinely struggle to find qualified certified firms. Your certification is not a decoration — it is a reason for a buyer to pick you.
- **Most of your competition never submits.** The paperwork wall filters out the majority of would-be bidders. Simply becoming a business that reliably submits compliant proposals puts you in a small minority.
- **Past performance is a chicken-and-egg problem with known solutions.** Every incumbent was once a first-timer. Chapter 6 covers exactly how firms with zero government past performance still win.

And the timing is unusual. Federal procurement is being rewritten right now — the 'Revolutionary FAR Overhaul' is streamlining the rulebook, raising purchase thresholds, and pushing more work into faster, simpler buying lanes. Faster buying favors vendors who are registered, findable, and ready. That can be you, and this guide is the readiness checklist.

From our playbook: Treat contracting as a pipeline business, not a lottery. Our own portal history spans dozens of bids across agencies — wins come from consistent, compliant at-bats, not one perfect swing.

Get Registered: UEI, SAM.gov, and the Portals

Nothing else in this guide matters until you can legally receive a government award. Registration is free — never pay a third party for something the government gives you at no cost.

Step 1 — Entity basics

- A legal business entity (LLC or corporation) in good standing with your state, with an EIN from the IRS. Your legal name, address, and bank details must match *exactly* across IRS, state, and SAM records — mismatches are the number-one cause of stalled registrations.
- A business bank account for electronic payments (government pays by EFT).

Step 2 — SAM.gov (free)

- Create your account at SAM.gov (login.gov credentials) and register your entity. You'll be issued a **Unique Entity ID (UEI)** — the government's identifier for your firm.
- Federal registrants receive a **CAGE code** during the process.
- Complete **Representations & Certifications** (reps & certs) carefully — these are legal statements about your business size, ownership, and compliance. Note: the FAR overhaul is changing reps & certs language, so re-read them at each annual renewal instead of clicking through.
- **Renew every 365 days.** An expired SAM registration makes you ineligible at award time. Calendar it twice.

Step 3 — Be findable

- Complete your **SBA profile (DSBS)** — contracting officers genuinely search it for small businesses. Write your capabilities the way a buyer would search: plain keywords, NAICS codes, certifications, a link to your capability statement.
- Pick your **NAICS codes** (the industry codes used to classify work and size standards). Choose one primary plus every secondary code you can honestly perform. You will search and be searched by these numbers.

Step 4 — State, local & tribal portals

Federal is only part of the market. Register with your state's procurement portal (in Arizona, that's APP — the Arizona Procurement Portal), your city and county vendor lists, school district cooperatives, and tribal procurement offices in your region. Each registration takes under an hour and each is a separate stream of opportunities most federal-only bidders never see.

From our playbook: Keep a single 'registration sheet' with your UEI, CAGE, EIN, NAICS codes, certification numbers, and portal logins. You will retype this information hundreds of times; having it in one place turns a 2-hour form into a 15-minute one.

Certifications: Turn Your Status Into an Advantage

Set-aside programs exist because Congress requires agencies to award portions of their spending to specific categories of small business. A certification does not win you contracts by itself — it narrows the field so dramatically that a good proposal can.

The federal programs

- **Small business (self-certified):** based on SBA size standards per NAICS code — revenue or employee count. Many solicitations are set aside for small business, period.
- **WOSB / EDWOSB:** Women-Owned Small Business — certification through SBA's portal or an approved third party. Applies to set-asides in industries where women are underrepresented, and increasingly beyond.
- **8(a) Business Development:** for socially and economically disadvantaged owners; a 9-year program that unlocks sole-source awards. The application is document-heavy — start early, and be meticulous: the program is under active audit scrutiny, which is good news for firms whose paperwork is airtight.
- **HUBZone:** based on the location of your principal office and where your employees live. Check the SBA map before assuming eligibility either way.
- **SDVOSB / VOSB:** service-disabled and veteran-owned certification (now certified through SBA).

State & local certifications

- **MBE / WBE / DBE:** minority-, woman-, and disadvantaged-business certifications used by states, cities, transit agencies, and prime contractors seeking diverse subcontractors. These matter enormously in SLED (state, local & education) contracting and in subcontracting plans on large federal work.

The strategy

- Certify in everything you legitimately qualify for — each one is another door.
- Put certifications on everything: capability statement, email signature, website, DSBS profile.
- Keep evidence organized: ownership documents, resumes, financials. Every program audits, and re-certification comes faster than you think.

From our playbook: Certifications also make you valuable to *primes*. Large contractors carry subcontracting goals for small and diverse businesses — your certification can get you onto a winning team before you ever prime a bid yourself.

Where the Bids Are (and How to Read One)

The sources

- **SAM.gov Contract Opportunities** — the federal front door: solicitations, sources-sought notices, and forecasts.
- **Grants.gov** — federal grants (especially relevant for nonprofits and programs).
- **FedConnect** — agency solicitations and awards for several major agencies.
- **DLA DIBBS** — Defense Logistics Agency purchasing for parts and commodities; huge volume of small, fast awards.
- **GSA eBuy** — task orders for GSA Schedule holders (a later-stage channel worth knowing exists).
- **SBA SubNet** — subcontracting opportunities posted by primes: often the realistic first rung of the ladder.
- **State/local portals** — your state's system (e.g., Arizona's APP), city and county sites, school cooperatives, and tribal procurement pages. Lower competition, simpler proposals, faster awards — the best training ground there is.

Know what you're reading

- **Sources Sought / RFI**: the agency is doing market research before a bid exists. Responding is free positioning — it can shape the requirement and even trigger a small-business set-aside if enough capable small firms respond (the 'Rule of Two' works in your favor here).
- **RFQ (Request for Quote)**: usually simpler, price-driven purchases. Great first bids.
- **RFP (Request for Proposal)**: full technical and price proposals evaluated on stated criteria.
- **IFB (Invitation for Bid)**: sealed bidding — lowest responsive, responsible bid wins.

Anatomy of a federal solicitation

Two sections run your life as a bidder: **Section L** (instructions — what to submit, format, page limits, deadline, delivery method) and **Section M** (evaluation criteria — how you'll be scored). Read M before L, and L before anything else. State and local bids compress these into 'Submission Requirements' and 'Evaluation Criteria' sections that serve the same purpose. One caution for 2026: FAR clause numbers are being reorganized under the overhaul, and new solicitations already reference the updated structure — always work from the clauses cited in *this* solicitation, never from an old template.

From our playbook: Set a fixed 30-minute daily 'portal sweep' — or automate it. Deadlines are unforgiving; amendments (changes to an open solicitation) are common; and the Q&A window is your one chance to get ambiguity resolved in writing.

Bid / No-Bid: Choosing Fights You Can Win

The most expensive mistake in contracting is not losing — it's spending 40 hours on a proposal you had no realistic chance of winning. Before you write a word, score the opportunity honestly:

- **Can we actually perform?** Not 'could we figure it out' — could you start on day one and staff it?
- **Is there an incumbent?** Look up prior awards for this requirement on USAspending.gov. A long-tenured incumbent with strong performance is a headwind; a recompetes after problems, or a brand-new requirement, is an opening.
- **What did winning cost last time?** Prior award values give you a price-to-win band. If your realistic price is far above it, no-bid.
- **Is it set aside for a certification we hold?** Set-asides shrink the field to firms like yours.
- **Do we meet every mandatory requirement?** One 'shall' you can't satisfy — a license, a bond, a facility clearance — is disqualifying. No-bid and move on.
- **Can we write a compliant proposal by the deadline, at our current capacity?** A late proposal is a dead proposal, no exceptions.

Score honestly, decide fast, and keep a log of your no-bid reasons — patterns in that log will tell you what capability or certification to add next.

From our playbook: Small dollar amounts are not beneath you. A \$4,000 award and a \$100,000 award both create past performance, a CPARS record, and an agency relationship. Early on, the reference is worth more than the revenue.

The Proposal: Compliance First, Persuasion Second

Evaluators score proposals against the solicitation's stated criteria — nothing else. The winning formula for a first-timer is unglamorous: be perfectly compliant, be specific, and mirror the solicitation's own language.

Step 1 — Shred the requirements

Go through the solicitation line by line and extract every 'shall,' 'must,' 'will provide,' instruction, and evaluation factor into a spreadsheet: requirement, where it appears, which volume answers it, and status. This is your **compliance matrix**. Professionals call this 'shredding,' and it is the single habit that separates real proposals from hopeful ones. Submit nothing until every row says 'addressed.'

Step 2 — Build the volumes

- **Technical Approach:** answer *how* you will do the work — their scope, restated in their vocabulary, with your method, staffing, timeline, and quality controls. Specific beats impressive: '3 crews, EPA-registered disinfectants, supervisor QC walk within 24 hours of each service' outscores 'world-class cleaning solutions' every time.
- **Past Performance:** relevant work with names, dates, values, and outcomes — and a contactable reference for each.
- **Price/Cost:** exactly in the format requested (Chapter 7).

Step 3 — The zero-past-performance play

If you have no government past performance, do not apologize for it — substitute for it, in this order:

- **Relevant commercial work:** the evaluation asks about relevant experience; private-sector contracts of similar scope count. Present them in the same name/date/value/outcome format.
- **Key personnel:** your people's experience is your experience. If your project lead ran similar work elsewhere, their resume carries real evaluation weight.
- **Teaming:** subcontract under an experienced prime (find them via SubNet and agency small-business offices), or bring an experienced subcontractor onto your team. You gain their past performance story and they gain your certification.
- **Start small and local:** state, local, and micro-purchase-level work builds the record fastest.

Many evaluations also state that firms without relevant past performance receive a 'neutral' rating rather than a failing one — meaning your technical volume and price carry the day. Read Section M; if past performance is neutral-rated, that solicitation is a first-timer's friend.

Step 4 — Strengthen before you submit

- Read the evaluation criteria one final time and check your proposal answers each criterion *in the order and language the agency used*.
- Have someone who did not write it verify every Section L instruction: format, fonts, page limits, file names, delivery method, deadline.
- Submit early. Portals crash at 3:55 PM on due dates. Ours have. Plan to be done a day ahead.

From our playbook: Write the executive summary last, and make it do one job: connect your certifications, your team, and your approach to the agency's stated need in under a page. Evaluators are tired people reading stacks of these — reward the skim.

Pricing Without Guessing

First-timers lose in two directions: pricing so high they're not competitive, or so low the agency doubts they understand the work ('price realism' is a real evaluation concept). Build your price from the ground up:

- **Direct labor:** hours per task × loaded hourly rate for each role.
- **The wrap rate:** your fully-loaded multiplier on bare wages — payroll taxes, insurance, overhead (rent, software, admin time), and profit. Small services firms commonly land in the ~1.5–2.5× range on bare labor; compute yours honestly rather than borrowing anyone's number.
- **Materials/ODCs:** supplies, travel, subcontractors — with quotes where you can get them.
- **Basis of estimate:** keep a one-page record of how you built the number. Some solicitations require it; all negotiations benefit from it.

Then sanity-check top-down: what have similar awards actually gone for (USAspending.gov, state portal award histories)? If your bottom-up number sits far outside the historical band, your estimate is wrong or the fit is wrong. And one 2026 note: purchase thresholds are rising under the current reforms, which pushes more buys into simplified, faster procedures — good news for small firms who are ready with clean, defensible pricing.

From our playbook: Never price to lose money for the 'foot in the door.' A contract you can't perform profitably damages the only asset that compounds in this industry: your performance record.

The 2026 Rulebook Rewrite: What Actually Changes for You

Federal acquisition is in the middle of the 'Revolutionary FAR Overhaul' — the most significant restructuring of the Federal Acquisition Regulation since its creation. It is arriving in phases: agencies first adopted changes through interim 'class deviations,' and formal proposed rules are now publishing through 2026. Here is what a first-time bidder actually needs to do about it:

- **Never reuse old clause citations.** FAR parts and clause numbers are being renumbered and reorganized, and new solicitations already use the revised structure. Copying last year's boilerplate or a downloaded template can literally point evaluators to the wrong clause — careless at best, non-responsive at worst. Always cite from the current solicitation.
- **Expect faster, simpler buying.** Thresholds for simplified procedures are rising and paperwork is being cut. Speed favors vendors who are already registered, findable, and decision-ready — and punishes those who need six weeks to get organized after seeing a bid.
- **Watch your reps & certs.** SAM representations and certifications are changing with the overhaul; read them fresh at renewal instead of re-clicking last year's answers.
- **Rules now expire.** A new sunset mechanism reviews non-statutory FAR provisions on a cycle — meaning the rulebook will keep moving. Build a habit (or use tooling) that tracks changes rather than assuming what you learned once stays true.
- **You get a voice.** Proposed rules publish with public comment windows on [regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov), and small businesses rarely comment — which makes the ones who do disproportionately loud. Commenting also teaches you the rules faster than any course.

The strategic takeaway: disruption resets the field. Incumbent advantages built on mastery of the old rulebook are partially expiring. For a prepared newcomer, this is the best entry window in decades.

After You Submit: Q&A;, Amendments, Debriefs, and the Long Game

- **Amendments:** agencies modify open solicitations constantly — scope, dates, requirements. You must acknowledge amendments as instructed or risk being found non-responsive. Track every bid you've submitted until award.
- **Q&A;:** if anything is ambiguous, ask during the question window. Answers are shared with all bidders and become part of the record — a well-placed question can reshape a requirement in your favor.
- **If you lose — request the debrief.** Federal procedures give you the right to feedback on many procurements, and even informal feedback requests on state/local bids often get answered. Debriefs are the cheapest proposal training available: agencies tell you exactly why you lost.
- **If you win:** perform impeccably, invoice correctly and promptly, communicate early when problems arise, and treat your **CPARS** (performance rating) like the credit score of your government career — because it is.
- **Either way, keep the relationship.** Contracting officers and agency small-business specialists remember responsive, professional vendors. Introduce yourself to your target agencies' Offices of Small Business Programs — helping firms like yours is literally their job.

From our playbook: Win rate math: even strong small firms lose most bids. A 1-in-5 hit rate with ten quality bids a quarter builds a real business. Judge yourself on pipeline discipline, not on any single award.

Your First 90 Days: The Checklist

Days 1–14 · Foundation

- Entity, EIN, and bank account aligned; SAM.gov registration started; NAICS codes chosen.
- Registration sheet created (UEI, CAGE, EIN, NAICS, logins in one document).

Days 15–30 · Visibility

- SAM active; DSBS profile completed with searchable keywords; one-page capability statement built (who you are, core competencies, differentiators, past performance, certifications, codes, contact).
- State portal + city/county vendor registrations done; certification applications started for every program you qualify for.

Days 31–60 · Pipeline

- Daily or automated sweep of SAM, your state portal, and SubNet; respond to at least two sources-sought/RFI notices (free reps at positioning).
- Bid/no-bid scorecard in use; identify 3 target agencies and introduce yourself to their small-business offices; pursue one subcontracting conversation with a prime.

Days 61–90 · Submit

- Submit your first 2–3 compliant bids — sized to win, not to impress. Build the compliance matrix on every one, no exceptions.
- Request feedback/debriefs on every result; log lessons; adjust and re-load the pipeline.

Ninety days of this puts you ahead of the majority of businesses that talk about government contracting forever and never file. The government buys from businesses that show up correctly, repeatedly. Show up.

Go further: FinesseWins — our software platform — runs this entire playbook for you: one search across every major bid source, winnability scoring from real award data, AI-drafted proposals (with a zero-past-performance mode), compliance checking, and amendment alerts. Built by our team, used on our own bids. finessewins.com — free tier available.

Questions about this guide: contact@millennialscreatives.com